Module 4: Problem Framing and Prioritization

Detailed supplement: framing, Jobs To Be Done, the Five Ws, traps and an assignment, with worked examples

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MODULE 4 · HOW TO USE THIS SUPPLEMENT

Coverage map: what is new and what is already in the module

Read this supplement next to the main Module 4 handbook. **Extended** means the handbook has the topic and this PDF adds the deck's example or exercise. **New** means the topic was not in the handbook.

Topic	Handbook section	Status here
Problem framing and problem discovery	4.1	Extended: the difference, and what good framing looks like
Good and bad framing (ivory tower, HiPPO)	—	New: the elevator example and framing traps
Double diamond	—	New: diverge and converge across problem and solution
Root cause: 5 Whys	4.2	Extended: the puddle example
Jobs To Be Done	—	New: a food-ordering example in two contexts
How Might We (HMW)	—	New: how to write and vary HMW questions
Five Ws	—	New: who, what, when, where and why, with a worked signup problem
Solution approaches	4.3	Extended: four candidate solutions for one problem
Customer journey and empathy	—	New: a food-ordering journey and opportunity mapping
MoSCoW	4.5	Extended: the 'what happens if not met' test
Kano model	4.5	Already covered; not repeated here
Deadly prioritisation traps	—	New: HiPPO effect, feature factory, false urgency
Paradox of choice	—	New: why fewer options can help users decide
Take-home: high basket size	4.11	New: assignment brief and outline

NOTE ON THE SOURCE

The deck's framing and prioritisation charts are partly image-only. Where a slide had no readable text, it is not described here. The examples are labelled as illustrative; scores and numbers are not real company data.

EXTENDED · SECTION 4.1

Problem discovery vs problem framing

Problem discovery finds what is wrong for users. **Problem framing** turns the market and user insights into one clear, agreed problem that is worth solving. The deck's definition is: framing is 'the act of defining what game you are playing before you start playing it'.

Good framing	Bad framing
Starts from the user's problem and the evidence.	Starts from a solution someone already likes.
Is specific enough to test and to say no to.	Is so broad that any feature seems to fit.
Is agreed by the team and the stakeholders.	Is decided by the loudest person in the room.

NEW · GOOD AND BAD PROBLEM FRAMING

The elevator example and the HiPPO trap

The deck uses a building-owner example. Tenants complain that the elevator is old and slow, and threaten to leave. Most people frame this as 'replace the lift' or 'install a stronger motor'. The building managers framed it differently: **'the wait for passengers in the lift is annoying'.** That framing opens a cheaper answer: install mirrors, so people have something to look at while they wait.

The lesson: the same complaint can lead to a costly fix or a simple one, depending on how the problem is framed.

Framing style	What it looks like	Why it hurts
Ivory tower	Decisions made far from users, on theory.	Solves a problem nobody has.
Misplaced empathy	Decisions made from one loud user's story.	Over-fits one case.
H.I.P.P.O. (highest paid person's opinion)	Decisions made from the most senior opinion.	Skips the evidence the team needs.

The deck places the goal in the middle: a **sweet spot** where decisions are user-centric and backed by evidence, aimed at the right problem.

PRACTICE

Take a feature you are proud of. Write its problem in two framings: one as a solution, one as a user outcome. Which one would survive a sceptical stakeholder?

NEW · PROBLEM SOLVING

The double diamond: diverge, then converge

Problem solving means diverging and converging across two spaces. In the first diamond you explore the problem widely, then narrow to one clear problem. In the second you explore solutions widely, then narrow to the ones you will test.

1. **Discover:** gather qualitative and quantitative research on the user problem.
2. **Define:** frame the key problem well, using JTBD, the Five Whys and HMW.
3. **Develop:** list many solution approaches before choosing.
4. **Deliver:** prioritise, build a small test and measure it.

WATCH OUT

Teams often skip straight from discover to deliver. The define and develop steps are where most of the value is.

EXTENDED · SECTION 4.2

Root cause: the Five Whys

Start with a specific problem and keep asking 'why' until you reach the root cause. Separate causes from symptoms. Base each answer on facts and data.

Step	Question	Answer (puddle example)
Problem	What is happening?	There is a puddle of water on the floor.
Why 1	Why is there water on the floor?	The overhead pipe is leaking.
Why 2	Why is the pipe leaking?	Water pressure in the pipe is too high.
Why 3	Why is the pressure too high?	A control valve is faulty.
Why 4	Why was the valve not caught?	Control valves have not been tested.
Root cause	Why are they not tested?	Control valves are not on the maintenance schedule.

The fix is not to mop the floor. It is to add valves to the maintenance schedule. The same method works for product problems, such as a drop in sign-ups.

NEW · JOBS TO BE DONE

Frame the job the user is hiring a product to do

Jobs To Be Done (JTBD) describes the situation, the motivation and the outcome, not the demographic. The deck uses one food-ordering product with two different jobs:

Situation	Motivation	Outcome
When I am tired after a long day of work	I want to order food quickly	So I can eat and feel better
When I have a short break at work	I want to order food quickly	So I can eat soon and get back to work

The same app serves both jobs, but the second job has less time. A design that works for the first job may fail the second.

NEW · HOW MIGHT WE

Writing HMW questions

A How Might We (HMW) question turns a problem into an invitation to explore. Build one like this:

- Write a concise problem statement.
- Break it into its parts: user, action, context.
- Choose an action verb that invites action.
- Name the subject of the challenge.
- Add a provocative element to spark fresh ideas.
- Vary the verb, subject and provocation to get several questions.

The deck's example: **'How might we help busy or tired users place an order with little cognitive load?'**

NEW · FIVE WS

Who, what, when, where and why

The Five Ws test a problem from five angles before you solve it.

Question	Ask	Example for a signup drop
Who?	Who experiences the problem? Who decides?	New users on mobile who start signup but do not finish
What?	What is the problem? What outcome is expected?	Signups fell 25 percent over three weeks
When?	When does it happen? When is the need most critical?	Only after the step where users enter their phone number
Where?	Where does the process break down?	Inside the signup flow, not on the landing page
Why?	Why does the problem exist? Why are current solutions inadequate?	Unknown until data and interviews are checked

EXERCISE (FROM THE DECK)

Over three weeks, signups fell 25 percent. The drop is concentrated in the signup flow, but the root cause is unclear. Use the Five Ws to write three hypotheses. For each, name the data that would confirm or reject it.

NEW · SOLUTIONING

From a user journey to opportunities

The deck maps a food order as a journey: **decide, order, wait, receive**. Under 'decide', a user chooses cuisine, restaurant, dishes and quantity. Under 'order', the user checks details, confirms price and delivery time, and applies coupons. Under 'wait', the user waits. Under 'receive', the food arrives.

The deck's reading: there is an opportunity to make the decide and order steps less demanding, but the decision step carries the more severe problem. Users often cannot choose quickly when there are too many options.

Candidate solutions for one problem

The deck lists four ways to reduce the load when a user is tired or busy:

- An AI-driven personal recommendation engine.
- A chat with a language-model assistant that finds the right order.
- Show the top orders in the user's area right now.
- Show the last order and prompt the user to repeat it.

Each candidate should be scored on the evidence and effort it needs. The deck marks one as the preferred option; check the slide in your copy before you decide, because the reasoning matters more than the label.

NEW · DEADLY TRAPS

Three traps that break prioritisation

Trap	Symptom	Example (deck)	Cure
The HiPPO effect	The most senior person's pet feature wins. The team drops everything.	Yahoo's 'Project Purple'	Depoliticise with scores: 'Data says X scores 45 and Y scores 120.'
Feature factory syndrome	Success is measured by features shipped, not outcomes.	Microsoft's Zune versus Apple's iPod	Reframe roadmaps as outcomes, for example 'increase activation to 50 percent'.
False urgency	A fire-drill culture where important strategic work never starts.	Not given	Reserve about 30 percent of capacity as buffer, so the planned 70 percent is not derailed.

Recognise these patterns before they damage the roadmap. Each one is a signal to re-check the framing, not only the ranking.

NEW · DECISION MAKING

The paradox of choice

More choice can make users feel worse. The deck's point: an obsession with choice pushes users to look for more, and they end up less satisfied. Restricting choice can help users decide quickly and improve the experience. Examples to test: a short list of recommended items, or a default option that users can change.

WATCH OUT

Restricting choice is a hypothesis, not a rule. Test it with real users, and watch for users who feel trapped or cannot find what they need.

ASSIGNMENT

Take-home: raise the basket size

Imagine you are a PM at a quick-commerce company, tasked with raising the average basket size (average order value).

1. Frame the key problem or problems. Use the Five Ws and JTBD.
2. Do primary or secondary research. Segment users by shopping behaviour, and identify what stops them from adding more items.
3. List the top solutions to increase average order value. Justify each with a clear reason tied to a blocker.
4. Prioritise the top one or two solutions. Use MoSCoW or Kano, and say which evidence would change your mind.

SELF-CHECK

Is each solution tied to a named blocker? Did you name a segment? Did you say what would change your priority?

NOTE

Use real public data where you can, label every assumption, and do not present invented figures as findings.

Quiz with answers

1. What is the difference between problem discovery and problem framing?
   Answer: discovery finds what is wrong for users; framing turns the insights into one clear, agreed problem.
2. In the elevator example, what framing led to a cheap fix?
   Answer: 'the wait for passengers in the lift is annoying', which led to installing mirrors.
3. Write the Five Whys chain for a drop in signups until you reach a root cause.
   Answer: an example chain, such as signup form error, then a validation change, then no test for that step, then testing not on the release checklist.
4. Name the four steps of the double diamond.
   Answer: discover, define, develop, deliver.
5. What is the HiPPO effect and its cure?
   Answer: the highest paid person's opinion wins; cure it with scores and data.
6. Why does a feature factory measure the wrong thing?
   Answer: it counts features shipped, not outcomes users get.

MODULE 4 · FINAL

Completion checklist

Completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Read the coverage map and marked the new topics
☐	Framed one problem in two ways and tested them
☐	Completed the Five Ws exercise on the signup drop
☐	Wrote the Five Whys for one real problem
☐	Completed the take-home assignment with labelled assumptions
☐	Answered the quiz without notes